



## **First Year Experience Peer mentorship programme**

First year attrition has been highlighted as a challenge faced by many universities both locally and internationally (Gill, Ramjan, Koch, Dlugon, Andrew & Salamonson, 2011; Krause & Coates, 2008; CHE/Scott, 2013; Scott *et al.* 2007). Research conducted on student engagement in South Africa, reflects the importance of “extending educational practices beyond the formal curriculum” (SASSE 2012), placing emphasis on providing opportunities for students to engage with the university and the environment by providing them with academic, social and psychological support. Peer mentoring has been widely recognized as one of the support programmes offered at CPUT to first year students to improve retention and success rates

### **Purpose:**

- To facilitate smooth transition between school and university
- To socialise the first year students into the university
- To provide psycho-socio support to first year students

### **What is peer mentoring?**

Peer mentorship is an interpersonal support relationship between two students, a senior student (a mentor, 2<sup>nd</sup> year level of study and above) assisting a first year students (mentee) (Kram, 1985). The mentor provides guidance, support, and offer advice to the first year students.

Peer mentoring is conceptualized as a mutually beneficial relationship for both the mentor and the mentee (Beltman and Schaeben, 2012; Budge, 2006; Clarke, Andrews and Gorman (2012/2013); Du Preez, Steenkamp and Baard, 2013).

### **Roles and responsibilities of a mentor**

Mentors assist students in seeking guidance on a range of pastoral matters including but not limited to the following issues; homesickness, loneliness, relationship issues, bullying, bereavement, health issues, concerns relating to academic ability, substance abuse and financial issues.

Where the mentor considers it appropriate, they may advise that the student seeks additional

support from the support services the student.

### **Training of mentors**

Mentors attend a 2-day training workshop facilitated by Student Counselling, HIV/AIDS Unit, Disability Unit, Student Welfare, Centre for Innovative Education Technology (CIET), International Office and the FYE.

### **Process of mentoring**

#### **Identification of mentors**

Lecturers in departments and residence coordinators identify students to be trained as mentors.

The chosen students are required to have a consistent pass in their courses with an **average of at least 65 % in the exams**.

#### **Matching mentors with mentees**

Matching can be done in any of the 3 ways:

- Lecturers can identify students to be mentored
- First year students can approach the mentor on their own
- Mentors can approach students themselves

#### **Meetings**

Mentors should meet with the mentees at least once a week individually or in a group